SUMMARY · MK 1 ORGANIZATIONAL BEHAVIOR & MANAGING PEOPLE · WEEK 5

Team Dynamics — Communication, Ego States & High-Performing Teams

How teams work: the cohesiveness vs performance-norm matrix, Tuckman's stages, five habits of high-performing teams, psychological safety, active listening, the power of words, and Eric Berne's Transactional Analysis (Parent–Adult–Child ego states).

Material

1 Team condition matrix: cohesiveness × performance norm

	Low performance norm	High performance norm
High cohesiveness	**"Dangerous" zone** — united around low standards.	**High Performing Team**.
Low cohesiveness	**"Grey" zone** — individualistic, low performance.	**"Agent" zone** — individualistic but performing.

Trick question: in the grey zone, should you raise cohesiveness? **Not yet** — you'd create the dangerous zone. **Raise the norm first** (grey → agent), then build cohesion (agent → high performing).

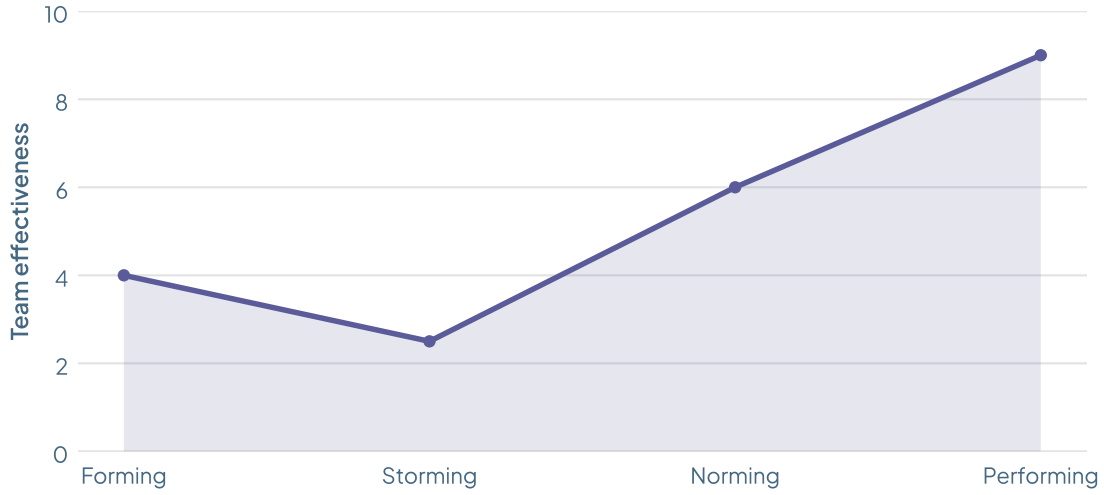
Tuckman: Forming → Storming → Norming → Performing → Adjourning. Storming conflict is normal.

2 Team development stages (Tuckman): why new teams dip first

Deep dive

Teams pass through forming, storming, norming, performing and adjourning; storming is normal.

Team performance by Tuckman stage (conceptual)



Conceptual: performance often dips in storming.

Stage	Leader's role
Forming	Clarify goals and roles
Storming	Surface and resolve conflict
Norming	Reinforce high-performance norms
Performing	Give autonomy
Adjourning	Celebrate, capture lessons

Link to cohesiveness × norms
Cohesion amplifies whatever norms exist.

3 Building a high-performing team

Five habits: communicate directly; make meetings matter; build relationships beyond work; a culture of appreciation in every direction; authenticity with psychological safety.

"Me" → "We" paradigm: individual growth mindset becomes collective; growth culture over genius culture; leaders shape it through policy, incentives and role modeling.

Psychological safety: the best teams *report more errors* — because they speak up, not because they fail more. Without it: silence, underreporting, repeated harm. Build a learning culture, not a blame culture.

4 Communication: active listening and the power of words

Active listening attunes to thoughts and feelings. Common failures: evaluating, probing, advising, interpreting; waiting to talk, checking your phone, saying "I get it" while missing the point. Good signs: eye contact, "What I hear you saying is…", clarifying questions, pausing before replying.

The 7–38–55 myth (Mehrabian). Called an urban legend (Lapakko, 2007) — the original study was narrow. Lesson: words, tone and body language must align.

Berger's magic words: similarity (linguistic fit — 3× more likely promoted), posing questions, emotion (roller-coaster stories), confidence/agency, concreteness ("30 minutes every Friday…" beats "be more innovative").

Workplace pillars: give context and why; balanced ego states; safety; active listening; fact-based criticism using **SBI (Situation–Behavior–Impact)**; complete asynchronous messages.

5 Transactional Analysis: Parent – Adult – Child ego states (Eric Berne)

An **ego state** is a way of expressing yourself in interaction; repeated, it becomes a pattern that can be analyzed and improved.

State	Traits	Example
Controlling Parent	Rules, commands, judging.	"Nobody leaves until this report is done."
Nurturing Parent	Caring, protecting.	"Not feeling well? Go rest, I'll cover."

Adult	Rational, fact-seeking, unemotional decisions.	"What data do you need from me?"
Natural Child	Spontaneous, playful, impatient.	"Love working with you!"
Adapted Child	People-pleasing, anxious, procrastinating.	"Yes ma'am, sorry..."
Little Professor / Rebellious	Creative, intuitive, sometimes manipulative/defiant.	"Ugh, can't we stop here?"

Transactions: *parallel* (expected response, smooth), *crossed* (unexpected state → conflict), *ulterior* (hidden message beneath the surface).

To exit a crossed transaction, **shift to Adult**; if that fails, ulterior transactions can save face. Key: analyze states, aim for parallel transactions, bring business to Adult, align words/tone/body, "I'm OK – You're OK", use all three states in balance.

6 Reading transactions: when communication flows and when it jams

Deep dive

Complementary
Response from the addressed state; talk flows.

Crossed
Response from another state; talk jams.

Ulterior
Hidden message behind a social one.

Example egogram of a manager

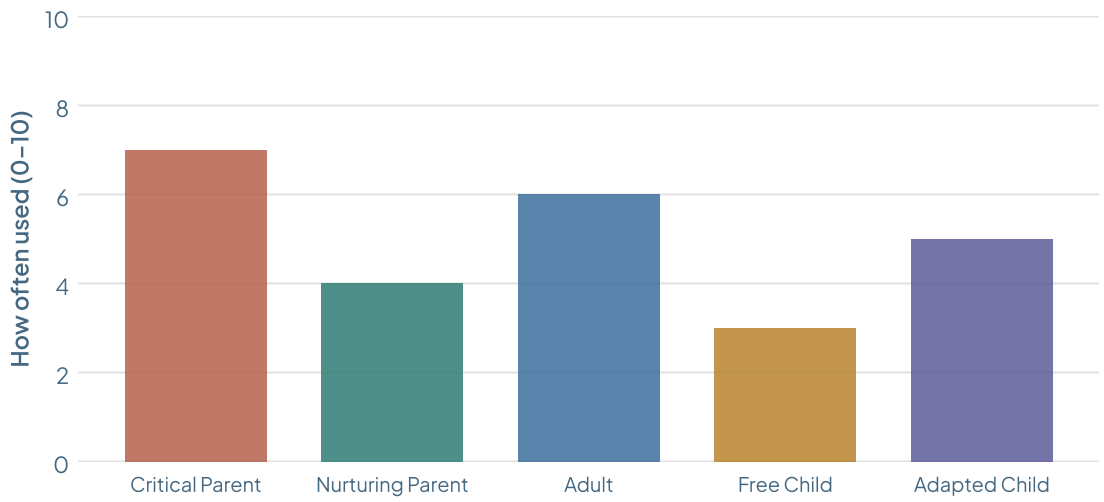


Illustration: a high Critical Parent pushes others into Adapted Child.

1. Recognise the other's ego state.
2. Don't get hooked.
3. Invite them to Adult with facts and questions.

7 Psychological safety: why the best teams report more errors

The slides sum it up in four points. They come from Amy Edmondson's (Harvard) hospital research in the 1990s. She expected the best nursing teams to make the fewest errors. The result was the reverse: the best teams **reported** more errors — not because they erred more, but because members spoke up. In fearful teams, errors are hidden and repeated.

Definition (Edmondson, 1999): a shared belief that the team is safe for interpersonal risk-taking — asking, admitting mistakes, proposing ideas and challenging views — without being embarrassed or punished. Google's internal research (Project Aristotle, 2015) also found psychological safety the most important factor in effective teams, above who is on the team.

What leaders do
Frame work as a learning problem ("we don't know the answer yet"); admit their own mistakes first; ask

What destroys it
Asking who's to blame before what went wrong; mocking questions; meetings where only the boss talks;

"what might I be missing?"; respond to bad news with thanks, not anger.

punishing people who raise problems.

> **!** **It doesn't mean "relaxed"**
> Psychological safety isn't low standards. Edmondson's matrix: high safety + high standards = **learning zone**; high safety + low standards = comfort zone; low safety + high standards = **anxiety zone**; both low = apathy.

Growth culture vs genius culture

The slides describe the shift from a "me paradigm" to a "we paradigm". A *genius culture* worships individual stars (talent seen as fixed); a *growth culture* believes everyone can grow through effort, coaching and learning from failure. Link to Week 4: Nadella moved Microsoft from "know-it-all" to "learn-it-all" and scrapped stack ranking — policies, incentives and leader role-modelling that support growth behaviours.

8 Effective communication: the slide's pillars, SBI and the 'power of words'

Four bad listening habits (from the slides)

Habit	Example	Replace with
Evaluating	"That's wrong!"	"How did you reach that conclusion?"
Probing (interrogating)	"Why did you do that?"	"Tell me more about the situation."
Advising	"You should just…" / "Here's what I'd do."	"What options have you considered?"
Interpreting	"You're just tired, that's why."	"What I hear is that you feel… right?"

Mehrabian's 7–38–55: beware the myth

The 7% words, 38% tone, 55% body language figures come from Mehrabian's (1967) very narrow experiments: participants heard *one word* expressing a

feeling (like/dislike) with *inconsistent* tone and face. The slides themselves cite Lapakko (2007): "communication is 93% non-verbal" is an urban legend — if it were true, why learn languages? The correct lesson: when words and tone/body language **conflict**, people trust the tone and body language.

Pillars of good workplace communication (slide table)

- **Context** — explain "why" and the benefit to reduce resistance.
- **Style** — use ego states in balance to match the other person.
- **Safety** — build trust and cooperation.
- **Active listening** — play back the other person's point before responding.
- **Fact-based criticism** — separate behaviour from identity; use **SBI**.
- **Clear asynchronous communication** — complete information in one message, fewer reply chains.

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SBI = Situation (when/where) → Behaviour (observable action, not a trait) → Impact (its effect)
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≡ **SBI example**

Poor: "You're unprofessional." Good: "In Tuesday morning's client meeting [S], you took two phone calls while the client was speaking [B]. The client paused and asked if we were busy, so it looked like we didn't value them [I]." SBI was developed by the Center for Creative Leadership.

Five "powers of words" (Jonah Berger, *Magic Words*)

Principle	From the slides	Example
Similarity	Employees whose language style matched co-workers' were 3× more likely to be promoted, with better ratings and bonuses	Use the target unit's terms ("omnichannel" in retail, "pivot" in startups)
Pose questions	Questions engage people and make them feel heard	"What do you think is riskiest?"

Emotion	Not just positive but emotional ("brilliant", "inspiring"); the best stories are roller coasters with highs and lows	Tell the setbacks before the success
Confidence / agency	Confident language persuades more than hedging	"I recommend…" rather than "Maybe we could…"
Concreteness	Concrete language is easier to understand and remember	Abstract: "Let's be more innovative." Concrete: "Every Friday, spend 30 minutes trying one new way to serve customers, then share the results on Monday."

9 Working through the Ego State exercise sheet

Answer directions for the "Ego State Exercise" sheet — thinking aids, not an official key.

Exercise 1 — identify the ego state

Line	Ego state	Adult version
"Why is your work getting so sloppy lately?"	Controlling/Critical Parent (judging the person)	"The last two reports had figure mismatches. What's getting in the way?"
"You're new here, just follow the way we usually do it."	Controlling Parent (rules/dogma)	"We do it this way because… What's the advantage of your approach?"
"Do this report, and don't mess it up like yesterday."	Controlling Parent (threat, dredging up the past)	"Please do this report by Thursday. Double-check the sales figures — something was missed last time."

Exercise 2

All three lines ("I see sales metrics dropped this month… what obstacles are you facing?", "Let's compare the pros and risks…", "I need this report by 2 pm… what

data do you need from me?") are **Adult**: fact-based, questioning, solution-focused, non-judgemental.

Exercise 3 — Budi (Product) vs Andi (Engineering)

Diagnosis: Budi speaks from *Controlling Parent* to Andi's Child ("You should be more disciplined!") in public. Andi replies from *Rebellious/Adapted Child* ("do it yourself then!") — a crossed transaction that triggers conflict and a work stoppage.

1. **De-escalate**: a facilitator/HR meets each separately in *Nurturing Parent* mode ("I understand the deadline pressure") to lower emotions, then shifts to Adult ("What actually happened?").
2. **A new Adult–Adult conversation**: Budi: "The launch on the 20th is at risk of slipping two weeks. I want to understand the technical blockers and how Product can help." Andi: "There were three requirement changes after the spec was frozen. If we prioritise the two core features, the 20th is still possible." → a parallel A–A transaction.
3. **Prevention**: agree a change-request process and a "no criticism in public" rule.

Exercise 4 — introductions at PT ABC (a state-owned construction firm)

The boss asks lightly ("what programme is that?") — from Natural Child/Adult. A good reply is **Adult with a touch of Natural Child**, short and humble: "P3MD, sir — a future-leaders development programme. I'm glad to join this affordable-housing project straight away." Avoid Critical Parent (showing off the programme) or Adapted Child (over-humble). When Rudi only nods (perhaps an awkward Adapted Child, or a sign of doubt), open an Adult conversation that respects his seniority: "Pak Rudi, I'll learn a lot from you. Where can I help first?" — building a parallel transaction and safety.

The "I'm OK – You're OK" life position

The slide's closing line comes from Transactional Analysis life positions (popularised by Thomas Harris, 1967). Four positions: I'm OK–You're OK (healthy, collaborative), I'm OK–You're not OK (looking down on others), I'm not OK–You're OK (self-deprecating), I'm not OK–You're not OK (hopeless). Adult–Adult communication comes most easily from the first.

Key takeaways

1. High cohesion + low norm = danger; raise the norm first.
2. Tuckman: forming → storming → norming → performing → adjourning.
3. Five habits: direct communication, meaningful meetings, relationships, appreciation, psychological safety.
4. Best teams report more errors because they feel safe.
5. Active listening: confirm, clarify, pause — don't judge or advise.
6. Use concrete, emotional, audience-matched language; criticize with SBI.
7. P-A-C ego states; parallel, crossed, ulterior transactions; shift to Adult to resolve conflict.

Case studies

Case & worked answers

Ego State exercise — with worked answers

Q1: "Your work is getting sloppier lately" → Critical Parent. "You're new, just follow our usual way" → Controlling Parent. "Do this report, don't mess up like yesterday" → Critical Parent.

Q2: All three ("I see sales metrics dropped — any obstacles?", "Let's compare pros and risks…", "I need this for tomorrow 2pm — what data do you need from me?") are **Adult** — the same messages as Q1, reframed.

Q3 — Budi vs Andi: Budi's public rebuke is Critical Parent → Child; Andi replies as Rebellious Child — a classic crossed transaction, worsened by loss of face. Fix: a facilitator de-escalates separately (Nurturing Parent); Budi reopens from Adult ("Feature X slipped 5 days — what's blocking, and how can Product

help?"); Andi answers from Adult ("Three requirement changes added ~4 days; defer two and we can still ship"). Use SBI.

Q4 — New at a state construction company after P3MD: answer the boss from a confident, brief Adult; open with silent Mr. Rudi from Adult + Nurturing, respecting seniority (see Week 6) and asking to learn from his experience.

Practice questions

Try answering first. The answer key is below each question.

1. A new team starts arguing over roles. Which stage?

A. Forming
B. Storming
C. Norming
D. Performing

Answer: B. Storming.

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2. Highly cohesive team with relaxed norms. Performance tends to be…

A. Very high
B. Low — cohesion reinforces weak norms
C. Unaffected
D. Always rising

Answer: B. Cohesion amplifies norms.

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3. "When will the report be done?" — "You always push people!" This is…

A. Complementary
B. Crossed
C. Ulterior
D. Adult-Adult

Answer: B. Adult stimulus, Parent response → crossed.

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4. Best response to a boss speaking from Critical Parent…

A. Angry reply
B. Comply resentfully
C. Stay Adult: facts and questions
D. Stay silent

Answer: C. Inviting Adult breaks the pattern.

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5. The leader's key role in forming is…

A. Full autonomy
B. Clarify goals, roles and rules
C. Avoid conflict
D. Disband

Answer: B. New teams need clarity.

Sources

- Week 5 Team Dynamics (Student Version).pdf
- Ego State Exercise.pdf